

"WE HAVE NOT CONCEDED A THING. WE RETAIN THE RIGHT TO TEST."

With the 45-member Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) amending its rules to permit civilian nuclear trade with India, it effectively ended 34 years of nuclear apartheid that had been imposed on the nation after the 1974 test. Days after India's success at Vienna, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee, the chief interlocutor for India's civilian nuclear deal, spoke candidly to Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA and Senior Editor SAURABH SHUKLA about India's nuclear future. Excerpts:

Q. How significant is the waiver by the Nuclear Suppliers Group?

A. It is the end of our nuclear isolation. After the 1974 test we faced severe restrictions. Our nuclear scientists were not even allowed to participate in international seminars. The NSG waiver has now given us the passport to conduct civilian nuclear trade with other countries. It is a recognition of India's special stature and it's impeccable record of non-proliferation. The international community is convinced that this civil nuclear co-operation is good for India and good for the world.

Q. Is the NSG waiver clean and unconditional as is being claimed?

A. Clean and unconditional are more or less the same. We have not accepted any unacceptable conditionalities and none of our redlines have been crossed. We have got a clean waiver. For instance, we did not want any condition imposed on us that we would not be permitted to conduct a test. We repeatedly pointed out that ours is a voluntary unilateral moratorium and we would not like to convert it into a treaty-bound obligation. Our position has been accepted by the NSG. They do not prohibit us from testing but that doesn't mean that we are permitted to do so by them. We have the right to act and they have the right to react. And if we act we have to face the consequences of all our actions.

"We can start nuke trade with other countries immediately, including Russia and France. With the US, we have to wait till its Congress passes the 123 Agreement."



Q. Did China's approach disappoint you?

A. If China was not part of the consensus, there would not have been one at the NSG. It is as simple as that. Their actions during the plenary were part of the normal decision-making process.

Q. But the national security adviser did say he was upset.

A. There may have been statements. What I am saying is the policy of the Government. I liked what the Chinese foreign minister said, which is that actions speak louder than words. And their action showed that they were part of the consensus.

Q. There is no domestic consensus as yet on the deal with both the BJP and the Left accusing you of selling India out.

A. I don't know how many times I have sold the country. In the 1980s, when as finance minister I borrowed money from IMF, the Opposition said I had sold our economic sovereignty. They said the same when I signed the WTO agreement in the 1990s. More recently, when I was defence minister, a similar accusation was made when I signed a framework agreement with the US. How many times can a thing be sold, resold and then resold?

Q. The BJP's point is that we have surrendered the right to conduct tests and that our